

ARCHEOLOGICAL EVIDENCE OF THE
UNITED MONARCHY OF ISRAEL

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Abstract

This paper serves as an archeological defense for the historicity of the united monarchy of Israel that is recorded in the Bible.

The United Monarchy of Israel in the Bible

The concept of the united monarchy originates from the biblical narrative. The term is used to describe the reigns of three successive kings—Saul, David, and Solomon—over a united Israelite kingdom. This period is primarily chronicled in the books of 1 and 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, and 1 Chronicles. According to these accounts, the united monarchy marked a pivotal era in Israel's history, transitioning Israel from a loose confederation of tribes under judges to a centralized monarchy. Traditional biblical chronology places the united monarchy between approximately 1050 BC and 930 BC. Saul's reign is thought to have lasted between 20-42 years¹, followed by David's 40-year reign (2 Samuel 5:4) then Solomon's 40 years (1 Kings 11:42). After Solomon's death, the kingdom split into the northern kingdom of Israel and the southern kingdom of Judah, marking the end of the united monarchy (1 Kings 12).

While the biblical account presents the united monarchy as a unified and powerful kingdom, its historicity has been a subject of much debate. Questions have arisen regarding the extent of the monarchy's control, the existence of monumental structures attributed to this

¹ The length of Saul's reign is heavily debated, primarily due to the interpretive issues surrounding 1 Samuel 13:1. This issue will not be explored in this paper.

period, and the reliability of the biblical texts as historical sources. These issues highlight the need for exploring archaeological evidence and extrabiblical sources in assessing the historicity of this period.

Biblical Archeology and Historical Reconstruction

However, before we begin, we should first pause to address the question: What is biblical archaeology, and what is the purpose of historical reconstruction? Biblical archaeology and historical reconstruction seek to bridge the gap between the biblical text and the archaeological evidence that is discovered. Do the archaeological discoveries align with or challenge the narratives of the Bible? At the heart of this endeavor is a critical question: “Do we have the right stuff, at the right place, at the right time?” In other words, do the artifacts, inscriptions, and architectural remains discovered in key sites correspond to the location and time period of events described in the Bible? This is what Biblical archaeology seeks to answer.

Scholars in this field often fall into one of three major interpretive camps. First, the Conservative/Maximalists, generally accepts the Bible as a reliable historical source, arguing that archaeological evidence proves the texts of the Bible. At the opposite end of the spectrum, **Minimalists** argue that the Bible is primarily theological, with little historical value for reconstructing the history of Israel. Lastly, Moderate/Centrist Scholars occupy a middle ground, treating the Bible as a complex mix of historical memory and later literary embellishment. This spectrum of opinion stresses the importance of evaluating archaeological findings critically and situating them within their geographical and temporal frameworks.

In the remainder of this paper, I will argue that the conservative approach is not only viable but also the most compelling framework for understanding the united monarchy of Israel.

This perspective is not based on a simplistic "because the Bible says so" mentality but is instead grounded in robust archaeological evidence that aligns with the biblical depictions of this period.

Archeological Evidence of the United Monarchy of Israel

In the last 50 years, loud voices in the minimalist camp have tried to make the claim that there is no evidence for the united monarchy of Israel.² They claim that the details in the biblical text are too exaggerated to be true and that, rather, these stories are most likely a later fabrication that reminisce a fictitious Golden Age.³ However, with the overwhelming amount of archaeological discoveries that have been found concerning the united monarchy, even moderate scholars have shifted the debate from “did figures like David and Solomon even exist?” to “who were David and Solomon?”⁴ This paper discusses the evidence that caused this shift and address some of the ongoing conversations around the united monarchy. While moderate scholars like Israel Finkelstein will try to adjust the dates of the archeological evidence to challenge the dates and claims of the Bible, the conservative view holds a more compelling framework for

² Israel Finkelstein, a moderate scholar, references Thomas L. Thompson and Niels Peter Lemche in discussing the lack of evidence for the united monarchy. He is likely referencing their works that challenge the historicity of early Israelite narratives, including the united monarchy. Both scholars are central figures in the Copenhagen School, a minimalist approach to biblical history. Israel Finkelstein and Neil Asher Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed: Archaeology's New Vision of Ancient Israel and the Origin of Its Sacred Texts* (New York: The Free Press, 2001), 217.

³ Ibid., 218-19 and Josh McDowell and Sean McDowell, *Evidence That Demands a Verdict: Life-Changing Truth for a Skeptical World*, updated and expanded ed. (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2017), 504. Both authors make the same claim, that the minimalists have attributed these texts to a later 6th century BC Judaism, most likely during the Deuteronomist reform of king Josiah (2 Kings 22-23), who, for political and religious propaganda, fabricated a “golden age” of Israel’s past. The McDowells however disagree with the minimalists and will argue that the archaeological evidence for this claim is unfounded. Finkelstein agrees with the skepticism of the minimalists towards the united monarchy but integrates his skepticism with the archeological evidence that validate the existence of David and Solomon.

⁴Finkelstein and Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed*, 217. Finkelstein himself admits that “the question we must therefore face is no longer one of David and Solomon’s mere existence,” admitting that evidence overwhelming favors the history of David and Solomon. He will however challenge their presentations depicted in the Bible.

understanding these artifacts. The cumulative weight of the archaeological evidence for the United Monarchy shows that we must take the Biblical narrative not as mere myth, but as a reflection of a historical reality.

The Tel Dan Stele

Perhaps the most pivotal discovery in the conversation on David is the Tel Dan Stele. Discovered in 1993 at the biblical site of Tel Dan, The Tel Dan Stele is a broken piece of basalt stone with Aramaic inscriptions engraved on its surface. The stone dates to the 9th century BC. What is significant about this stone is the inscription itself. The text records details of an invasion of Israel by an Aramean king. While the name of the king is not recorded on the stone fragment, it is almost universally accepted to be referring to Hazael, King of Damascus, who raided the northern kingdom of Israel around 835 BC.⁵ The inscription reads, “*I killed [Jeho]ram son of Ahab, king of Israel, and I killed [Ahaz]iah son of Jehoram, king of the House of David.*” This inscription was the first extrabiblical record of David to ever be found. Its discovery marked a turning point in biblical archaeology.

The Tel Dan Stele is significant for three major reasons. First, the Tel Dan Stele confirms the existence of David - something minimalist scholars had sought to disprove for decades before the Stele’s discovery.⁶ Second, the Stele helps date David to his biblical chronology (around 1000 BC). With the practically unquestioned historicity of the kings Ahab and Ahaz⁷, the Stele documents the existence of the Davidic dynasty within one hundred and

⁵ Finkelstein and Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed*, 219.

⁶ Niels Peter Lemche, *Ancient Israel: A New History of Israelite Society* (Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1988).

⁷ The Kurkh Monolith, an Assyrian inscription from 853 BCE, records the Battle of Qarqar, where King Ahab of Israel is listed as part of a coalition of kings opposing the Assyrian ruler Shalmaneser III.

fifty years of the end of Solomon's reign. This dismantles the claim that David was an invention of 6th-century BC Jews seeking to promote political and religious propaganda. Instead, David emerges as a legitimate historical leader who predated the 9th century BC. Third, the Tel Dan Stele shows the magnitude of David's renown. This counters the minimalist claim that David was merely a local tribal chief whose legends were exaggerated over time. Even Finkelstein concedes that the stele's mention of the "House of David" is "clear evidence that the reputation of David was not a literary invention of a much later period" and that it "clearly validates the biblical description of a figure named David becoming the founder of the dynasty."⁸

Thus, the Tel Dan Stele not only affirms the historicity of both David as an individual and his "house" as a ruling dynasty, but it also forces scholars to recognize that his impact extended well beyond his immediate context. When weighing this evidence, the biblical account of David's kingship and rule over Israel emerges as the most coherent explanation of this inscription.

⁸ Finkelstein and Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed*, 219-220. However, Finkelstein will go on to diminish the exploits and magnitude of David's dynasty and attribute much of this exaggeration to the propaganda of the Deuteronomist Jews of the 7th century BC. Finkelstein's argument against the united monarchy however is an argument from silence (lack of evidence), rather than a smoking gun. Finkelstein asserts that since we have found little evidence of documents, inscriptions, or artifacts that would be indicative of a central monarchy, and presuming that a lack of artifacts equates to a low population in the southern highlands, he concludes there could not have been a dynasty ruling from Jerusalem during the 10th century. *Ibid.*, 240-241. Yet this argument not only diminishes the artifacts that have been found to support centralized government in the 10th century (these will be explored in later sections), it also ignores the plausible causes for lack of artifacts. Kenneth Kitchen, a leading voice in the conservative camp, offers two plausible arguments for the lack of materials dating to the united monarchy: destruction and state policy. First, Kitchen notes that most official documents would have likely been stored in either the palace or the temple, both of which were utterly destroyed in Israel's history. Second, Kitchen notes that it was possibly the policy of the state to not allow inscriptions. While not concrete, it is a possibility given the small amount of inscriptions found, even in later Israelite periods. Both cases must be considered when weighing this "lack of evidence" Finkelstein uses to found his arguments. Kenneth A. Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 2003), chap. 4, sec. 4.

Solomon's Activity: Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer

As a reminder, biblical archaeology asks “do we find the right stuff, at the right place, at the right time?” A good case study for this is found in 1 Kings 9:15. This verse records building campaigns initiated by king Solomon to reinforce the defenses of Israel during his reign. The biblical text notes that he fortified cities such as Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer. Thus, we would expect to find archaeological evidence of building efforts at these sites dating to the 10th century. That would be the right stuff, at the right places, at the right time. What then do we find at these sites?

Six-Chambered Gates at Megiddo, Hazor and Gezer

The first excavation of the three sites was at Gezer in 1902-1907. The dig uncovered remnants of walls and a gate dating to the 10th century. The next excavation took place at Megiddo in the 1920s and 30s. The dig revealed city fortifications, a 6-chambered gate, and large administrative buildings dating to the Iron Age (1200 to 500 BC).⁹ This evidence fits the biblical account of Solomon's efforts swimmingly. In the 1950s, an excavation at Hazor was led by Yigael Yadin. He and his team discovered a large city gate with six distinct chambers dating to the Iron Age.¹⁰ This gate mirrored the design and size of the gate found at Megiddo almost exactly. Yadin re-examined the findings at Gezer and argued that the remains there were actually the same six-chambered gate found at both Hazor and Megiddo.¹¹ Therefore, at all the sites

⁹ P.L.O. Guy, *New Light from Armageddon: Second Provisional Report (1927–29) on the Excavations at Megiddo in Palestine*, Oriental Institute Communications 9 (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1931).

¹⁰ Finkelstein and Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed*, 234-235.

¹¹ Ibid., 235. Yet Finkelstein will go on to dispute Yadin's claim that these gates all connect to the same time period of Solomon. See bullet point 17 for further discussion on the shifting of dates. However, William Dever states that if the same credibility was given to the bible as other historical documents, there would be no question on the dating of these gates. William G. Dever, *What Did the Biblical Writers Know and When Did They*

mentioned in 1 Kings 9:15, we have the same 6-chambered gate, all dating to the 10th century. The consistency in architectural design across these sites indicates a programmatic building effort and a unified administration capable of executing large-scale construction, which is best explained by the biblical account of united monarchy during Solomon's reign.

Gezer and Siamun's Interactions with Solomon

Gezer is also mentioned in 1 Kings 9:16-17. The bible states that "Pharaoh king of Egypt had gone up and captured Gezer and burned it with fire, ...and had given it as dowry to his daughter, Solomon's wife; so Solomon rebuilt Gezer." The account provides two key details for investigation. First, the mention of a Pharaoh's campaign into Canaan suggests we should look to Egyptian records to corroborate this activity. Second, evidence of Gezer's destruction by fire should be visible in the stratigraphy of the site as destruction by fire leaves a noticeable indicator in the strata.

Based on Egyptian records, the king we would expect to correspond with Solomon would be Siamun.¹² Egyptian archeology supports the biblical account, indicating that Siamun had activity in Canaan.¹³ Similarly, findings in the strata show destruction dating to the 10th century, which would correlate to the destruction of Gezer by Siamun as depicted in 1 Kings 9.¹⁴ The critics of the biblical narrative try to shift the dates of the destruction of Gezer (along with

Know It? What Archaeology Can Tell Us About the Reality of Ancient Israel (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 2001), 1517.

¹² Alberto R. Green, "Solomon and Siamun: A Synchronism between Early Dynastic Israel and the Twenty-First Dynasty of Egypt," *Journal of Near Eastern Studies* 42, no. 1 (1983): 41–45

¹³ Kitchen describes the finding in Tanis as a clear indication of a relief on Siamun into the Levant. He notes the critics of the view will mention that the fragment in Tanis is an unnamed king, despite an inscription that can only be reasonable translated and attributed to Siamun. Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament*, chap. 4.

¹⁴ Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament*, chap. 4

other dates related to all of Solomons cities) to different time periods,¹⁵ but a recent discovery of a seal of Siamun discovered at Gezer all but shuts down any attempt to disprove the biblical narrative as it relates to the city of Gezer.¹⁶ With the gate of Gezer firmly planted in the 10th century, having been built after Saiman's raid, the biblical account is the most viable for understanding Gezer's history and the gates found at Gezer, Megiddo, and Hazor.

Jerusalem's Issues and Excavations

Perhaps the biggest archaeological critique from the minimalist and moderate camps on the united monarchy is the lack of artifacts and presumed low level of inhibition in the southern highlands (the area containing and surrounding Jerusalem) during the 10th century.¹⁷ In fact, most of Finkelstein's views seem to stem from this very issue. Is there evidence for a thriving capital city during the time of David and Solomon? Why have we not found remains of Solomon's palace or temple? And why do we have no inscriptions, seals or other evidence that would be indicative of a powerful capital city in a thriving monarchy? We will address these questions in this section.

¹⁵ Kitchen notes that several of Finkelstein's studies aim to shift the dates of all archaeological phases from 1180 onward. He notes that Finkelstein chronology would shift the match gates found at Gezer, Megiddo, and Hazor to different periods. However, he goes on to note that this is unfounded, arguing that the strata Finkelstein attempts to move is better explained when gaps are taken out of the 11th and 12 century. [I will admit, his argumentation was a little over my head]. Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament*, chap. 4. Yet even moderate scholar Amihai Mazar notes that Finkelstein's lower chronology "creates many unanswered problems" and suggest alternatives. Amihai Mazar, "The Iron Age Chronology Debate: Is the Gap Narrowing? Another Viewpoint," *Near Eastern Archaeology* 74, no. 1 (2011): 50–54.

¹⁶ "A newly excavated seal of Siamun found at Tel Gezer," Stephan Munger, Steven Ortiz, and Samuel Wolff (in preparation). While the final report is not yet published, this Siamun seal puts to silence any attempt to move the destruction of Gezer IX to another time period.

¹⁷ Finkelstein even admits that his struggle with the evidence at Megiddo stems from his view on Jerusalem saying, "is it possible that a king who constructed fabulous ashlar palaces...ruled from a small, remote, and underdeveloped village?" Finkelstein and Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed*, 239-240.

First, it is important to note there are several challenges in ascertaining archaeological evidence from Jerusalem. First, many of the key areas, such as the Temple Mount, prohibit excavation. Since Solomon's Temple is thought to have been located on the Temple Mount, the inability to investigate this area leaves a significant gap in the evidence. Furthermore, the city has endured repeated destruction and rebuilding¹⁸, which likely obliterated or displaced much of the archaeological evidence we would expect to find there. Lastly, Jerusalem has been continuously inhabited for over 3,000 years. This continuous occupation compresses and disrupts archaeological layers, making it extremely difficult to isolate artifacts. Kenneth Kitchen, a conservative scholar, also notes that only an exceedingly small percentage of the area in question has actually been excavated (3-5%), and large conclusions on the data should be made with much caution.¹⁹ There are also still vast amounts of area in Jerusalem that cannot be excavated because they are under residential homes. Thus, we should expect a lower number of archaeological findings in Jerusalem. However, critics of the biblical account will use this lack of evidence to challenge the record of the united monarchy.²⁰

Excavations in Jerusalem and their Findings

What do the excavations in Jerusalem produce? Admittedly, the evidence in Jerusalem leaves a bit to be desired. However, most of this can be attributed to the above

¹⁸ Babylonian conquest in 586 BC to the Roman destruction in 70 AD.

¹⁹ Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament*, chap. 4, section on Jerusalem.

²⁰ They do so because excavations in Jerusalem produce Bronze Age and early Iron age artifacts, just not artifacts from the late Iron Age II that would date to the time of David and Solomon. Thus, Finkelstein's only conclusion is that Jerusalem of the 10th century was only a "typical hill country village." Ibid., 228. Yet, Mazar spills a considerable amount of ink to disprove Finkelstein's conclusions around the evidence in Jerusalem and the southern highlands. He argues that both Jerusalem and other areas like Khirbet Qeiyafa and Gezer reveal both pottery and strong building activity dating to the 10th century that can only reasonably be attributed to the united monarchy. Amihai Mazar, "Jerusalem in the 10th Century B.C.E.: A Response," *Zeitschrift des Deutschen Palästina-Vereins* 136, no. 2 (2020): 139–151.

reasons. Perhaps the two most notable archaeological finds that help attest the biblical account of David's activity in Jerusalem are the Stepped Stone Structure and the Large Stone Structure. These large stone constructions were found on the upper eastern slope of the city of David. When the Large Stone Structure was found to be connected to the Stepped Stone Structure, archeologist Eilat Mazar claimed that she had discovered David's palace.²¹ Yet, her findings quickly came under fire. Scholars like Finkelstein argued that the structure actually consisted of multiple buildings all dating to different periods, some of which predate the time of David and the more elaborate pieces dated to the Hellenistic period.²² Later discussions around the findings concluded that E. Mazar's dates were most likely wrong. Yet, scholars like Amihai Mazar argue that Finkelstein's dating of "multiple structures" does not tell the whole story. A. Mazar argues that most of the structure dates to the end of the Iron Age I or the Early Iron Age IIA and was continually used and added to until 586 BC.²³ Most of the structure, he argues, would correspond to the time of the Jebusites who held the site before David. Though probably not David's palace, the structures prove that Jerusalem was much more than a small village. Containing an extremely large structure (probably a fort and wall), it most likely served as a powerful military center for both the Jebusites and the united monarchy of Israel. Thus, the evidence in Jerusalem, while sparse, does not disprove the biblical account. Instead, it supports its credibility by noting Jerusalem as an important city in the area, not some "underdeveloped village" as Finkelstein claims.

²¹ Eilat Mazar, *The Palace of King David: Excavations at the Summit of the City of David* (Jerusalem: Shoham Academic Research and Publication, 2009).

²² Israel Finkelstein, "Has King David's Palace in Jerusalem Been Found?" *Tel Aviv: Journal of the Institute of Archaeology of Tel Aviv University* 34, no. 2 (2007): 142–164.

²³ Amihai Mazar, "Jerusalem in the 10th Century B.C.E.: A Response," *Zeitschrift des Deutschen Palästina-Vereins* 136, no. 2 (2020): 139–151

Additional Artifacts that Support the Biblical Account

I do not have the space in this work to provide an in-depth analysis of all the evidence supporting the historicity of the united monarchy. However, in this section, I will briefly outline a few additional archaeological discoveries that corroborate the biblical record of the united monarchy, providing an avenue for further independent study if desired.

Khirbet Qeiyafa

Khirbet Qeiyafa is a fortified city dating to the 10th century. Excavations there have uncovered massive fortifications and early Hebrew inscriptions that suggest a literate and organized society in Israel during the 10th century. This provides massive support to the biblical account of a united monarchy under David and Solomon's reign.²⁴

Mining Activity in the Jordan Rift Valley

Archaeological evidence of copper mining and metallurgical activity, particularly at sites like Timna and Faynan, has been found and dates back to the 10th century. These mining operations suggest the existence of a complex economic system and centralized administration. This further supports the Bible's description of Solomon's wealth and extensive building projects (1 Kings 9:26–28).²⁵

²⁴Yosef Garfinkel, "Khirbet Qeiyafa in the Shephelah: Data and Interpretations," in *Khirbet Qeiyafa in the Shephelah*, ed. S. Schroer and S. Münger, *Orbis Biblicus et Orientalis* 282 (Fribourg: Academic Press, 2017), 5–59.

²⁵Erez Ben-Yosef, "A New Chronological Framework for Iron Age Copper Production at Timna (Israel)," *Antiquity* 84, no. 325 (2010) and Thomas E. Levy, "High-Precision Radiocarbon Dating and the Iron Age in the Southern Levant: Time, Materials, and Culture," in *The Bible and Radiocarbon Dating: Archaeology, Text, and Science*, ed. Thomas E. Levy and Thomas Higham (London: Equinox Publishing, 2005).

The Mesha Stele (the Moabite Stone)

The Mesha Stele, also known as the Moabite Stone, is a basalt inscription discovered in Dhiban, Jordan in 1868. It dates to around 840 BC and was commissioned by King Mesha of Moab. The Mesha Stele supports the idea of a united monarchy by confirming Israelite dominance over Moab during the time of the Omride dynasty (2 Kings 3), which implies that Israel had the political and military infrastructure necessary to control neighboring territories. The stone also has a probable, though contested, mention of the house of David.²⁶

The Shoshenq Relief

The Shoshenq Relief is an Egyptian inscription carved into the Karnak Temple in Egypt. It was commissioned by Pharaoh Shoshenq I (the biblical Shishak) in the mid-10th century BC and details his military campaign into Canaan. The relief confirms Egyptian activity in Canaan during the 10th century and supports the biblical account of Shishak's invasion during the reign of Rehoboam (Solomon's son) depicted in 1 Kings 14:25–26.²⁷

Conclusion

In conclusion, the archaeological evidence discovered to date offers substantial support for the historicity of the united monarchy of Israel. The biblical narrative provides the most viable framework for interpreting the numerous archeological findings that point toward a centralized kingdom in the 10th century. The evidence concludes that the united monarchy of

²⁶ Lemaire argues that the only logical conclusion of the phrase on the stone is “House of David.” André Lemaire, *The Mesha Stele and Omride Dynasty: Royal Inscriptions of the Ancient Near East* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 1997), referenced and quoted in McDowell and McDowell, *Evidence That Demands a Verdict*, 516-517.

²⁷ Kitchen, *On the Reliability of the Old Testament*, chap. 4, sec. 5c.

Israel was not merely an exaggerated piece of political propaganda, but rather a defining reality in the history of God's chosen people.

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